

DECCAN QUEEN

The 191-km distance between Bombay and Poona (Pune) used to take four days before the railways connected the two cities and reduced the travel time to six hours. The trains negotiated the steep and rapid 600-m ascent to Bhore Ghat (see [Conquering The Ghats](#)), before descending into the plains towards Poona. When the Great Indian Peninsula Railway's (GIPR) Deccan Queen debuted on 1 June 1930, this journey further whittled down to two hours and 45 minutes.

Named after Poona's sobriquet, Queen of the Deccan, this intercity train originally ran only on weekends. It was not till 1943 that it became a daily connection. Legend has it that in its heyday, the Deccan Queen ferried Europeans to the races in Poona during the weekends.

The train was introduced with two rakes of seven coaches. While the underframes of the original coaches were imported from England, the bodies were made in the GIPR's Matunga Workshop in Bombay. A rarity for the time, the Deccan Queen was not hauled by using steam traction, but an electric locomotive – the first Indian train to be pulled by one.

It had many other firsts attached to its name – from being the first Indian train to have a vestibule (an enclosed space between coaches to allow easy passage), to having a “Ladies Only” compartment. Its crowning feature, however, was its dining car – half kitchen, half restaurant – which served hot meals to its passengers. The menu included fried fish and chips, baked beans on toast, cheese toast, and chicken cutlets.

One of the most iconic trains run by the Indian Railways, this express train today is the fastest from Mumbai (Bombay) to Pune, a lifeline for those who travel from one city to the other every day for work. The Deccan Queen entered its 90th glorious year of service in 2019.